SPEED MEETS COMFORT

With the indigenously made Vande Bharat Express, India has revolutionised train travel—it's faster, convenient and more efficient than ever

By AVISHEK G. DASTIDAR



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

VANDE BHARAT EXPRESS
Launched on Feb. 15, 2019

Achievement: As of Dec. 2024, Indian Railways operates 136 Vande Bharat trains across the country, connecting 68+ cities and slashing journey times by 25-45 per cent

THE DRUDGERY

Not long ago, a "superfast" train journey in India, like Delhi to Varanasi for instance, still meant spending 10-12 hours on the move—food, sleep, and multiple trips to dirty toilets included. Trains that averaged 70-80 kmph over long distances were considered fast enough. Comfort was often an afterthought—passengers endured tight seating, bumpy rides and outdated facilities on most routes. The Shatabdi Express, introduced in 1988, had ushered in speed and comfort, reaching 110-150 kmph, but it still lagged far behind global standards. Automatic doors and modular toilets had yet to make an appearance, and plush interiors could be found only in brochures. Frequent stops and unpredictable schedules made long-distance travel tedious, leaving passengers to find solace in fleeting views of the countryside or conversations with co-travellers.

THE EASE OF LIVING

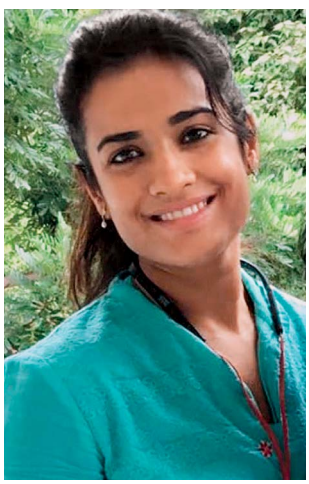
Then came the Vande Bharat Express, which has revolutionised train travel in India ever since Prime Minister Narendra Modi flagged off its first service from Delhi to Varanasi on February 15, 2019. Designed and built by the Integral Coach Factory (ICF) in Chennai under the 'Make in India' initiative, this self-propelled train could reach speeds of up to 180 kmph, even though it got approval only for a maximum of 160 kmph. Covering that first 760-km journey in eight hours, it set new benchmarks for

HOW IT TRANSFORMED MY LIFE

"I actually prefer it over flying"

An Air India executive, Maansi has travelled around the world. Yet, for the past three years, she finds equal joy in travelling closer to home. A Delhi resident, she frequently accompanies her family to Dehradun, where they have a second home, and to the Vaishno Devi shrine in Katra, Jammu. Both destinations are now conveniently connected to the national capital by the Vande Bharat.

"Earlier, we used to take the Shri Shakti Express to reach Katra,



MAANSI MALHOTRA, 40
Air India executive, Delhi